

# Balsamic-Roasted Zucchini and Chickpea Skillet with Soft Cheese

2 small zucchini (about 6 ounces/168g each)  
1 teaspoon salt, divided  
1 (15-ounce/425g) can chickpeas, drained and rinsed  
½ small red onion, sliced  
2 tablespoons extra-virgin olive oil, divided  
1¼ teaspoons garlic powder, divided  
½ teaspoon freshly ground black pepper, divided, plus more to taste  
2 teaspoons balsamic vinegar  
1 teaspoon honey or brown sugar  
4 ounces (113g) soft crumbly cheese such as goat cheese, Boursin, or brine-packed feta  
1 tablespoon heavy cream, plus more to taste  
Chopped fresh herbs, such as basil, lemon thyme, chives, or oregano, for serving  
Extra-virgin olive oil, for serving (optional)

## TIPS & TRICKS

To increase the yield on this recipe, double the ingredient measures and cook the zucchini in a large skillet as directed. Instead of transferring the skillet to the oven, coat a rimmed baking sheet with olive oil, then transfer the browned zucchini to one-half of the baking sheet and the chickpea mixture to the other and roast as directed.

Every so often, I like to challenge myself to make a dish so satisfying, so filling, and so flavorful that you'd never realize (or at least miss) that there's no meat. While I don't believe that you need meat (or seafood) to make a meal complete, I fully realize that it takes a little more convincing for others. That's when I turn to legumes like chickpeas, which are full of protein and are also a great canvas for herbs and spices. For this recipe, I'm also turning up the dial on one of my favorite summertime vegetables, zucchini, which gets a sticky, savory-sweet balsamic glaze as it roasts with the chickpeas. That's just enough time for you to mix up some tangy whipped cheese, which everything gets saucily spooned over. **SERVES 2**

Preheat the oven to 425°F.

Halve the zucchini lengthwise. With the tip of a sharp knife, make diagonal marks on the flesh side of each zucchini half, about ½-inch deep and ½-inch apart. Try not to cut all the way through! Repeat on the other diagonal to create a crosshatch pattern.

Sprinkle ½ teaspoon of the salt over the cut sides of the zucchini and let stand for 15 minutes. (This will draw out and remove excess moisture, which means your zucchini will brown and not steam.)

Meanwhile, in a medium bowl, combine the chickpeas, onion, remaining ½ teaspoon of salt, 1 tablespoon of the olive oil, ½ teaspoon of the garlic powder, and ¼ teaspoon of the pepper. Stir to combine.

Blot the zucchini dry with paper towels. Season the cut sides of the zucchini with ½ teaspoon of the garlic powder and ¼ teaspoon of pepper. Set aside.

In a small bowl, stir together the balsamic vinegar and honey and set aside.

Heat the remaining tablespoon of oil in a 12- to 14-inch oven-safe skillet over medium-high heat. When the oil shimmers, place the zucchini cut side down in the skillet. Cook undisturbed until deep golden brown, about 5 minutes. Remove the pan from the heat.

Flip the zucchini and push the slices to the edges of the pan. Give the balsamic mixture a quick stir, and drizzle it over the zucchini. Add the chickpea mixture to the center of the skillet; it's ok if it's mounded.

Transfer the pan to the oven and roast for 15 minutes. Stir the chickpeas and continue roasting until the zucchini is tender, 5 to 10 minutes more.

While the zucchini roasts, crumble the cheese into a medium microwave-safe bowl and add 1 tablespoon of the cream. Microwave on high for 15 seconds, or until the cheese is just softened and warm. Add the remaining ¼ teaspoon of garlic powder and stir vigorously or whisk to combine until mostly smooth. The mixture should be soft and spreadable. If needed, add a touch more cream. Season with salt, if desired.

Spread the cheese over a serving plate. Top with the roasted chickpea mixture and zucchini. Sprinkle with herbs and a couple cracks of black pepper. Finish with a drizzle of olive oil, if desired.

## Variations

**USE YELLOW SQUASH OR JAPANESE EGGPLANT** in place of the zucchini. The cooking method remains the same.

**ADD YOUR FAVORITE HERBS OR SEASONINGS TO THE CHEESE SPREAD.** Minced fresh chives, basil, garlic, and lots of freshly ground black pepper would work well.

